Just as vitally, will North Korean nukes be armed and ready for detonation as soon as they are mated to missiles? In the US case, nuclear weapons can be enabled only by entering a twelve-digit code, known as the permissive action link (PAL), into the weapon itself.[13] Without the PAL, the weapon remains in safe mode, thus providing yet another layer of negative control preventing the unauthorized use of nuclear weapons. There is as yet no indication that North Korea has instituted a PAL system, and unless Pyongyang decides to tell us, we may never know whether it has enabled such a system.

At the heart of the nuclear enterprise is the turning of the launch key. No one yet knows what North Korea's nuclear release procedures will be. While Kim Jong-un likely will keep all control over nuclear weapons in his hands, he won't physically fire the missile, so he must delegate that authority in some way. Will Kim have the equivalent of the American president's nuclear "football," with its menu of launch options? Once Kim has decided what he wants to do, will the order go from him solely to the commander of the Strategic Rocket Forces, the military unit that presumably controls North Korea's nuclear ballistic missiles? Or will Kim want to give orders directly to the field units, which, in addition to the mobile launchers, comprise fixed launch pads and possibly an underground silo complex, not unlike the US Minuteman III force?

Nor do we know how North Korea's launch orders will be electronically or physically transmitted. Moviegoers remember scenes of US nuclear launch officers cracking open the thin red "wafers" holding the alphanumeric codes in movies such as *War Games* and *Crimson Tide*. Will North Korean missile officers receive similar electronic "emergency action messages" that are confirmed by opening "sealed authenticator envelopes" containing the unique codes for launch, thus ensuring that only proper commands are received? Perhaps a simple telephone call from Pyongyang will suffice to launch nuclear weapons, but that is less secure and possibly more vulnerable to misinterpretation during a crisis or third-party interference.